



THE BOYLE HEIGHTS Bridge Runners Club runs across the 6th Street Bridge, which is unlit on Oct. 1.

‘Ribbon of light’ loses shine

When the 6th Street Bridge opened, it was promoted as a gateway to usher in a new era for Los Angeles, an architectural masterpiece showcasing the city’s place on the world stage before the 2026 World Cup and the 2028 Summer Olympics.

With its 10 rising arches, illuminated with thousands of LEDs to look like a ribbon of light for miles around, the bridge was hailed as the next L.A. monument, up there with the likes of the Hollywood sign and the “Urban Light” assemblage at the Los Angeles County Museum of Art.

But three years later, the lofty aspirations for the bridge have gone dark, along with its rising arches, because of copper thieves. Today, the viaduct is less an emblem of urban architectural modernity and more a safety risk for drivers, joggers and pedestrians crossing the Los Angeles River at

The 6th Street Bridge, once a glowing landmark, has gone dark after copper wire theft

By Nathan Solis



ON BROADWAY and 23rd in downtown, cut wires can be seen from one of L.A.’s historic streetlights.

night.

The 6th Street Viaduct was the city’s most expensive bridge project to date, costing an estimated \$588 million, and was meant to set off a wave of other public projects across the city. According to estimates from city officials, the thieves who stripped the bridge’s copper wiring probably netted about \$11,000.

But it will cost the city \$2.5 million to assess and repair the damage, according to Councilmember Ysabel Jurado, whose district includes downtown and Boyle Heights.

“It’s fully funded, and it will be lit, I’ve been assured by many departments, by the 2028 Olympics,” Jurado said about the proposed repairs. She’s also asked the city to allocate \$1.7 million in discretionary funds for a dedicated streetlight repair team in her district.

[See Bridge, A9]

New clean energy cuts target California

By Hayley Smith

Days after the Trump administration made headlines for canceling nearly \$8 billion in clean energy projects across 16 blue states, the Department of Energy is considering terminating an additional 300 projects totaling more than \$15.8 billion, according to a leaked list reviewed by The Times.

The list includes five of seven projects to develop clean hydrogen energy in the United States awarded under President Biden. Funding for the other two so-called hydrogen hubs was terminated last week, including California’s project, the Alliance for Renewable Clean Hydrogen Energy Systems, or ARCHES.

The list is not an official document but comes via credible sources from inside the administration.

Other potential terminations include a \$500-million award to General Motors to convert an existing vehicle assembly plant in Michigan to electric vehicle production, and two major carbon-capture projects in Indiana and North Dakota, which face cuts of \$500 million and \$350 million, respectively. (Carbon capture is the process of capturing planet-warming carbon dioxide emissions from industrial releases and storing or re-using them before they can

[See Energy, A12]

Housing law boosts transit hubs

Newsom signs historic bill that will allow taller, denser projects near transportation.

By Jack Flemming

On the campaign trail eight years ago, Gov. Gavin Newsom famously promised to support the construction of 3.5 million new homes in California by the end of this year. He’ll probably fall short by millions, but his latest move reaffirms the effort.

Newsom signed Senate Bill 79 into law Friday. The historic bill, which looks to add density to transit hubs across California, is one of the most ambitious state-

imposed housing efforts in recent memory.

“All Californians deserve an affordable place to live — close to jobs, schools, and opportunity. Housing near transit means shorter commutes, lower costs, and more time with family. When we invest in housing, we’re investing in people — their chance to build a future, raise a family, and be part of a community,” Newsom said in a statement.

The sweeping bill — which takes effect July 1, 2026 — upzones areas across California, overriding local zoning laws to allow taller, denser projects near transit hubs such as subway stops, light rail stops and bus stops with dedicated lanes.

Developers will be per-

mitted to build up to nine-story residential buildings adjacent to subway stops, seven stories within a quarter-mile of them and six stories within a half-mile. The bill will also allow residential buildings that reach five to eight stories near light rail and dedicated bus lanes, depending on how close a piece of property is to a particular station or bus stop.

It’s the second major housing reform Newsom has green-lighted this year. In June, he signed a landmark bill that streamlines housing construction and cuts through the regulatory red tape brought by the California Environmental Quality Act (CEQA).

Newsom’s decision caps

[See Housing, A9]

Voices GUSTAVO ARELLANO COLUMNIST

Ex-bracero does not want program to return

One May morning in 1961, 21-year-old Manuel Alvarado strapped on his huaraches, stuffed three changes of clothes and a thin blanket into a nylon tote bag and bid his parents farewell. He was leaving their rancho of La Cañada, Zacatecas, for *el Norte*.

The United States had been kind and cruel to his farming family. His uncles had regaled him with tales of the easy money available for legal seasonal workers — known as braceros — which allowed them to buy land and livestock back home.

His father, however, was

one of a million-plus Mexican men deported in 1955 during Operation Wetback, an Eisenhower administration policy of mass removal in the name of national security and taking back jobs for Americans.

“They sent my father to the border with only the clothes on his back,” Alvarado, now 85, told me in Spanish while sinking into a comfy couch at his daughter’s well-kept Anaheim home.

His father’s mistreatment didn’t scare Alvarado back then. He boarded a train with his uncles and cousins bound for Chi-

[See Arellano, A7]



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

MANUEL ALVARADO was part of the program that enlisted Mexican male laborers during the 1960s.

LAFD didn’t use vital tool to confirm Jan. 1 blaze was out

Thermal imaging wasn’t employed before Palisades fire erupted, officials say.

By Alene Tchekmedyian, Hannah Fry and Richard Winton

Los Angeles firefighters did not use thermal imaging technology to detect lingering embers underground after a New Year’s Day fire in Pacific Palisades that flared up days later to become one of the most destructive infernos in the city’s history.

Interim Fire Chief Ronnie Villanueva said in an interview Wednesday that fire officials decided against employing the technology, which could have pinpointed heat underground, because of the fire’s eight-acre size.

In the 36-plus hours that crews spent mopping up the Jan. 1 fire, which federal prosecutors say was deliberately started along a popular hiking trail, firefighters “cold-trailed” the perimeter, chopping a line around the fire and feeling for residual heat. They packed up and left on Jan. 2, then returned the next day, after a report of smoke in the area, for another round of cold-trailing, Villanueva said.

Villanueva downplayed

the effectiveness of the thermal imaging cameras, noting that some chaparral in the city extends 15 to 25 feet underground, while the depth of the department’s cameras is only a foot.

“We did everything that we could do,” he said.

Los Angeles Fire Department officials, already under scrutiny for their failure to pre-deploy engines in advance of the Palisades fire, are facing questions about why they didn’t fully extinguish the Jan. 1 fire before hurricane-force winds fanned an ember buried within the roots of dense vegetation on Jan. 7. The Palisades fire killed 12 people, charred 23,400 acres and leveled more than 6,800 structures, including many homes.

On Wednesday, federal prosecutors released documents charging a 29-year-old Uber driver with intentionally setting the Jan. 1 fire, called the Lachman fire. The documents also revealed the results of a federal investigation into the cause of the Palisades fire, which concluded that it was a “holdover” blaze — defined as a fire that remains dormant for a considerable time.

An LAFD after-action report also released Wednesday described shortcomings of the department’s

[See Imaging, A6]

As MIT rejects Trump deal, USC faces a dilemma

L.A. school’s faculty has denounced the demand to cede rights to ensure funding.

By Daniel Miller, Jaweed Kaleem and Collin Binkley

As USC weighs its options, MIT has become the first of nine universities to forcefully reject a White House proposal that asks them to adopt President Trump’s conservative political agenda in exchange for favorable access to federal funding.

In a letter to Trump administration officials, MIT

President Sally Kornbluth said Friday the campus disagrees with provisions of the proposal, including some that would limit free speech and the university’s independence. She said that Trump’s “Compact for Academic Excellence in Higher Education” is inconsistent with MIT’s belief that scientific funding should be based on merit alone.

“Therefore, with respect, we cannot support the proposed approach to addressing the issues facing higher education,” Kornbluth said in a letter to Education Secretary Linda McMahon and White House officials.

The MIT rejection comes as USC has been roiled by the proposed compact since receiving it earlier this month. The school’s faculty members strongly denounced the offering at a meeting this week, calling it “egregiously invalid,” “probably unconstitutional,” and “antithetical to principles of academic freedom.”

But interim President Beong-Soo Kim told the roughly 500 attendees the university “has not made any kind of final decision.”

At the same time, Gov. Gavin Newsom has aggressively weighed in, challenging USC “to do the right thing” and reject the offer. He threatened to withhold state funding to any California university that agrees to it.

White House spokesperson Liz Huston said that “the Trump Administration’s only request is for universities to end discrimination. Any university that refuses this once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to transform higher education isn’t serving its students or their parents — they’re bowing to radical, left-wing bureaucrats.”

“The truth is, the best science can’t thrive in institutions that have abandoned merit, free inquiry and the pursuit of truth,” Huston said. “President Trump en-

[See MIT, A7]

A star is born as Sasaki tantalizes

Dominance in Game 4’s clinching win of NLDS bodes well for Dodgers’ budding ace. **SPORTS, B11**

Machado wins Nobel for peace

Opposition leader is recognized as a “key, unifying figure” for Venezuela. **WORLD, A3**

Catalina’s deer in the crosshairs

Proposal to eliminate population using contracted hunters cites fire risk. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Lots of sunshine. L.A. Basin: 81/60. **B8**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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